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UNIVERSITY OF MANNHEIM
School of Social Sciences

Political Psychology in International Relations

BA Proseminar
Autumn/Winter Semester 2026
Wednesday 1:45pm–3:15pm
A 5, 6, Room B 143
Version: 1.2

This seminar introduces students to political psychology in international relations. We start with the basics of how international relations is usually studied and the assumption that states and leaders act rationally, then ask what changes once we take human psychology into account. Topics include misperception and threat, the personalities and small groups behind foreign policy decisions, identity and nationalism, public opinion, and the psychological roots of repression and political violence. By the end, you will have the conceptual tools to understand why leaders and publics do not always behave the way traditional international relations theory expects.



Guernica by Pablo Picasso (1937)†

† "On April 27, 1937, Nazi warplanes flew from Germany to the town of Guernica in the Basque region of Northern Spain and dropped bombs on the unsuspecting town for several hours. The town burned for 3 days, and most of the surrounding area was destroyed. More than 1,600 innocent civilians, one third of the local population, were killed. The obliteration of the Spanish town, little more than target practice for Hitler's incipient war machine, had been requested by a Spaniard, General Francisco Franco, the ultimately successful leader of a fascist coup to overthrow the democratically elected Spanish government. This horrible political event inspired Picasso's Guernica, the cover illustration for this book, a masterpiece that foreshadowed the Second World War. The painting symbolizes man's timeless struggle against tyranny, aggression, terrorism, war, corruption, nationalism, prejudice, and evil, and the image has been widely resurrected in the aftermath of September 11, 2001. Guernica captures ancient human themes that are among the core topics addressed by the science of political psychology." Quoted directly from Jost, J. T., & Sidanius, J. (2004). Political psychology: An introduction. In J. T. Jost & J. Sidanius (Eds.), *Political psychology: Key readings* (p. 1). Psychology Press/Taylor & Francis. DOI: 10.4324/9780203505984

Expectations

The goals of this seminar are

- to give you a working command of the psychological ideas that shape current research in international relations,
- to help you see the assumptions about individual behavior hidden inside theories of war, deterrence, and cooperation,
- to build your skill at reading empirical political science with a critical eye, and
- to guide you through designing your own original study of a political psychology question in world politics.

As a proseminar, this course does not assume advanced prior training. A basic familiarity with political science is helpful, but you do not need to have already taken a dedicated course in international relations. You do not need prior coursework in political/social psychology either. Everything we need from both fields, we build together in class. Further, a working sense of research methods, how to formulate a research question, how to read a literature review, and the difference between correlation and causation would all be useful, but I walk you through each written assignment with a detailed guideline well ahead of the semester.

I strongly encourage you to attend every session. This seminar runs on discussion, and a missed session is hard to make up on your own. If you feel overwhelmed at any point, please talk to me.

Workload and Materials

I have kept the required reading for each week to one main text, so that you can read it closely rather than skim several pieces. Each week's readings are marked in one of three ways.

- *** marks the required reading. Read this one **before** the session it is assigned to.
- – marks a recommended reading. I still consult this text and draw on it in class, but you are not required to read it. Treat it as a good next step if the week's topic interests you.
- An unmarked reading, listed under "Further readings for this week's presenting team or teams," is assigned to that week's presenters. They read it in depth and present it to the class. Any student is welcome to read it too, for their own interest or as background for the seminar paper.

Finding a reading through the library is also a skill you will need for your own seminar paper, so it is worth building early rather than late. Please consult the library in good time to make sure you can access each week's reading before the session, not the night before. The Primo Catalog is where to start.

Communication

Office hours: Wednesdays 4:00pm-5:00pm, Room 121. You are welcome to come without an appointment.

Ilias: I will post announcements here. Please check your university email account regularly.

Email: For questions about the seminar paper or your own progress, please come to office hours and/or email me directly at my university address.

Support

Studying with disabilities or chronic illness: Contact me and the relevant office at the university if you need accommodation. Please reach out early in the term so we can plan ahead together.

Learning support: If the readings or the writing assignments feel hard to manage, talk to me as soon as you can. The university also offers help with learning and study techniques.

Emotional resilience: Feel free to talk to me if the course feels like too much. The university offers a range of support options for stress, burnout, or other mental health concerns.

Counseling: The university offers counseling services for students facing harassment, discrimination, bullying, or difficulty balancing study and family life.

A Note on the Material

Some weeks touch on repression, torture, and political violence, and some readings describe this violence directly. If a reading or a case is hard for you for personal reasons, please come talk to me. We can find a way to keep you engaged with the seminar without asking you to sit through material you should not have to face without support.

We will also discuss cases where reasonable people hold strong and opposed views. Disagreement is welcome and expected. It should always be expressed with respect for the person on the other side of it. Personal attacks or attempts to shut another student down will not be tolerated at all.

Recording and Academic Honesty

Students may not record any part of the seminar, audio or video, without my written permission beforehand.

All students are expected to submit work that is their own. Using someone else's written words or ideas without credit, whether from a published source, a classmate, or a past student's paper, is plagiarism and will be treated as a serious academic offense. If you are drawing on a paper you wrote for another course, that is fine as a source of ideas, but the seminar paper you submit here must be newly written and newly argued for this course.

On Using AI Tools

You may use generative artificial intelligence (AI) tools to help you brainstorm, or to check your grammar and phrasing at the sentence level. You may not use them to write your argument, your literature review, or your hypotheses for you. The thinking in this paper has to be yours. I can tell the difference between a paper that reasons and a paper that summarizes, and a paper in the second category will not pass.

If you use an AI tool at any stage, add one short sentence at the end of your submission naming the tool and what you used it for. If you did not use one, say so in one sentence instead. This costs you nothing and takes around thirty seconds. Leaving it out is treated as a missing required component, not as an accusation, so there is no reason to skip it either way.

Requirements

This seminar has two parts, one graded and one pass or fail.

Seminar paper (graded, 100% of your grade). You will write a research design paper across four staged submissions, 3,000 words in total, not counting notes, references, or appendices. You first submit an introduction with a research question. Then a literature review with theory and hypotheses. Then a research design with data, variables, and method. Finally, a complete paper that pulls the earlier stages together, revised, with a discussion and a conclusion added. You get written feedback at each stage and are expected to use it in the next one. You do not need to carry out the empirical analysis yourself. The paper is graded on your ability to find a real gap in the literature, build a clear psychological argument, and propose a design that could actually test it.

Class participation (pass or fail). You are expected to attend regularly and come ready to discuss the reading. To pass this part, you cannot miss more than three sessions.

Weekly presentations (pass or fail). Starting in Session 2, two randomly selected students, assigned after the first session, present together on that week's further reading, like co-authors coordinating as a team. Each student does this only once during the semester. With 25 (±2) students in the class, one team may have three members instead of two, and most weeks will have two presenting teams working on two different readings rather than one. Your team should connect the reading to a current event/issue/case in world politics and bring at least two discussion questions to the class. The schedule will be posted well before the second session.

Design presentations (pass or fail). Near the end of the term, every student presents their research design to the class in a short, timed talk, and receives feedback from me and from their peers before writing the final version of the paper.

Full instructions for the seminar paper and the design presentation, along with fillable templates, are distributed separately and posted on Ilias.

Course Policies

Attendance

Attendance is taken each session. You may miss up to three sessions and still pass the participation requirement. If you must miss a session for a documented medical reason or another serious cause, tell me in advance where possible.

Late Submissions

Each stage of the seminar paper has a firm deadline, listed below. A late submission loses feedback time rather than points, since drafts one through three are pass or fail. Please still submit as close to the deadline as you can, since late submission of an early stage compresses the time you have to act on feedback before the next one. If you know in advance that a deadline will be hard to meet, write to me while there is still time to plan around it.

A Note on the Seminar Paper's Unit of Analysis

Your research question, theory, and hypotheses must be about individual people, not about states or countries as units. A leader, an adviser, a soldier, a diplomat, or a member of the public all count. Your study should be something you could in principle test by surveying people, running an experiment on them, or systematically coding what a set of people said and did.

This is the single place where papers in this seminar most often go wrong, so I want to be direct about it now. "Why do democracies rarely fight each other" is a question about pairs of countries. "Do citizens of democracies judge an attack on another democracy as morally wrong" is a question about people, close to the question Tomz and Weeks actually test in a reading assigned later in the term (Session 8). The first question cannot be answered in a term paper in this seminar. The second version can.

Ask yourself this before you settle on a topic. Could I answer this question by surveying people, running an experiment on them, or coding what specific people said and did? If the answer is no, come talk to me and we will reshape the question together.

Course Outline

- Session 1, October 7: Introduction, and the Rationalist Baseline in International Relations
- Session 2, October 14: Prospect Theory, Risk, and Framing
- Session 3, October 21: Misperception and Threat Perception
- Session 4, October 28: Emotion, Morality, and Taboos in World Politics
- Session 5, November 4: Leaders: Personality, Beliefs, and Profiling at a Distance
- Session 6, November 11: Small Groups and Foreign Policy Decision Making
- Session 7, November 18: Identity and Nationalism
- Session 8, November 25: Public Opinion and Foreign Policy
- Session 9, December 2: The Psychological Roots of Repression and Political Violence
- Sessions 10 and 11, (Saturday) December 5: Design Presentations
- Sessions 12-14, December 9: Wrap-up, General Feedback on Presentations, Future Directions

Note: This is a tentative reading list. Readings may be adjusted before or during the term. Any change will be announced on Ilias well ahead of the relevant session.

Session 1, October 7: Introduction, and the Rationalist Baseline in International Relations

What does it mean to say that a state or a leader acts rationally, and why has international relations built so much of its theory on that assumption? We spend this first session getting to know each other, going over the seminar plan, and laying out the rational baseline we will spend the rest of the term testing against actual human behavior.

*** Kertzer, Joshua D., and Dustin Tingley. "Political Psychology in International Relations: Beyond the Paradigms." *Annual Review of Political Science* 21, no. 1 (2018): 319–339. https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-polisci-041916-020042

– Hafner-Burton, Emilie M., et al. "The Behavioral Revolution and International Relations." *International Organization* 71, no. S1 (2017): S1–S31. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0020818316000400

Session 2, October 14: Prospect Theory, Risk, and Framing

If leaders cannot compute the fully rational answer, what do they do instead? This week looks at how people weigh gains and losses differently under risk, and what that asymmetry does to decisions about war and peace.

*** Levy, Jack S. "Prospect Theory, Rational Choice, and International Relations." *International Studies Quarterly* 41, no. 1 (1997): 87–112. https://doi.org/10.1111/0020-8833.00034

– Kahneman, Daniel. "Maps of Bounded Rationality: Psychology for Behavioral Economics." *American Economic Review* 93, no. 5 (2003): 1449–1475. https://doi.org/10.1257/000282803322655392

Further readings for this week's presenting team or teams:

McDermott, Rose. "The Iranian Hostage Rescue Mission." In *Risk-Taking in International Politics: Prospect Theory in American Foreign Policy*, 45–75. University of Michigan Press, 1998

Boettcher, William A. III. "The Prospects for Prospect Theory: An Empirical Evaluation of International Relations Applications of Framing and Loss Aversion." *Political Psychology* 25, no. 3 (2004): 331–362. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9221.2004.00375.x

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Session 3, October 21: Misperception and Threat Perception

Draft 1 due Sunday, October 25, 23:59

Two states can watch the same event and walk away believing two different things happened. This week asks where that gap comes from, and what it does to the odds of a crisis turning into a war.

*** Jervis, Robert. "War and Misperception." *Journal of Interdisciplinary History* 18, no. 4 (1988): 675–700. https://doi.org/10.2307/204820

– Stein, Janice Gross. "Threat Perception in International Relations." In *The Oxford Handbook of Political Psychology*, 2nd, ed. by Leonie Huddy, David O. Sears, and Jack S. Levy, 364–394. Oxford University Press, 2013. https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780199760107.013.0012

Further readings for this week's presenting team or teams:

Herrmann, Richard K. "Perceptions and Image Theory in International Relations." In *The Oxford Handbook of Political Psychology*, 2nd, ed. by Leonie Huddy, David O. Sears, and Jack S. Levy, 334–363. Oxford University Press, 2013. https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780199760107.013.0011

Búzás, Zoltán I. "The Color of Threat: Race, Threat Perception, and the Demise of the Anglo-Japanese Alliance (1902–1923)." *Security Studies* 22, no. 4 (2013): 573–606. https://doi.org/10.1080/09636412.2013.844514

Session 4, October 28: Emotion, Morality, and Taboos in World Politics

Some choices are refused not because they fail a cost-benefit test, but because making them at all feels wrong. This week looks at how emotion and moral conviction shape what leaders and publics will and will not do in world politics.

*** Fiske, Alan Page, and Philip E. Tetlock. "Taboo Trade-offs: Reactions to Transactions That Transgress the Spheres of Justice." *Political Psychology* 18, no. 2 (1997): 255–297. https://doi.org/10.1111/0162-895X.00058

– McDoom, Omar Shahabudin. "The Psychology of Threat in Intergroup Conflict: Emotions, Rationality, and Opportunity in the Rwandan Genocide." *International Security* 37, no. 2 (2012): 119–155. https://doi.org/10.1162/ISEC_a_00100

Further readings for this week's presenting team or teams:

Tannenwald, Nina. "The Nuclear Taboo: The United States and the Normative Basis of Nuclear Non-Use." *International Organization* 53, no. 3 (1999): 433–468. https://doi.org/10.1162/002081899550959

Lerner, Jennifer S., et al. "Emotion and Decision Making." *Annual Review of Psychology* 66 (2015): 799–823. https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-psych-010213-115043

Session 5, November 4: Leaders: Personality, Beliefs, and Profiling at a Distance

Does it matter who is actually in the room making the decision? This week looks at leader personality and belief systems, and at the methods scholars use to profile leaders they can never sit down and interview.

*** Hermann, Margaret G., et al. "Who Leads Matters: The Effects of Powerful Individuals." *International Studies Review* 3, no. 2 (2001): 88–131. https://doi.org/10.1111/1521-9488.00235

– Gallagher, Maryann E., and Susan H. Allen. "Presidential Personality: Not Just a Nuisance." *Foreign Policy Analysis* 10, no. 1 (2014): 1–21. https://doi.org/10.1111/fpa.12006

Further readings for this week's presenting team or teams:

Horowitz, Michael C., et al. "Sizing Up the Adversary: Leader Attributes and Coercion in International Conflict." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 62, no. 10 (2018): 2180–2204. https://doi.org/10.1177/0022002718788605

Renshon, Jonathan. "When Public Statements Reveal Private Beliefs: Assessing Operational Codes at a Distance." *Political Psychology* 30, no. 4 (2009): 649–661. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9221.2009.00718.x

A note for students planning an original design around (state, non-state armed group) leaders. If you want your seminar paper to profile a set of real world leaders from their speeches or interviews, the recent *R* package leadeR scores Leadership Trait Analysis and Operational Code Analysis directly from text. It sits alongside the survey archives listed in the design guideline as one option for building your own dataset, and it is entirely optional. Come to office hours if you want to talk through whether it fits your question.

Session 6, November 11: Small Groups and Foreign Policy Decision Making

Draft 2 due Sunday, November 15, 23:59

Foreign policy decisions are rarely made by one person alone. This week asks what happens to individual psychology once it is filtered through a room of advisers, and what that room keeps or throws away on the way to a recommendation.

*** Levy, Jack S. "Foreign Policy Decision-Making: The Psychological Dimension." In *The Oxford Handbook of Political Psychology*, 3rd, ed. by Leonie Huddy et al., 349–391. Oxford University Press, 2023. https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780197541302.013.9

– Mintz, Alex, and Carly Wayne. "The Polythink Syndrome and Elite Group Decision Making." *Political Psychology* 37, no. S1 (2016): 3–21. https://doi.org/10.1111/pops.12319

Further readings for this week's presenting team or teams:

Jost, Tyler, et al. "Advisers and Aggregation in Foreign Policy Decision Making." *International Organization* 78, no. 1 (2024): 1–37. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0020818323000280

Saunders, Elizabeth N. "No Substitute for Experience: Presidents, Advisers, and Information in Group Decision Making." *International Organization* 71, no. S1 (2017): S219–S247. https://doi.org/10.1017/S002081831600045X

Session 7, November 18: Identity and Nationalism

Groups can form around almost nothing and still generate real loyalty toward made-up ingroup members and real hostility toward fabricated outsiders. This week asks what follows once that basic group psychology is scaled up to the level of the nation.

*** Tajfel, Henri, and John C. Turner. "The Social Identity Theory of Intergroup Behavior." In *Political Psychology: Key Readings*, ed. by John T. Jost and Jim Sidanius, 367–390. Psychology Press, 2004. https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203505984-16

– Haslam, Nick, and Steve Loughnan. "Dehumanization and Infrahumanization." *Annual Review of Psychology* 65 (2014): 399–423. https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-psych-010213-115045

Further readings for this week's presenting team or teams:

Herrmann, Richard K., Pierangelo Isernia, and Paolo Segatti. "Attachment to the Nation and International Relations: Probing the Dimensions of Identity and Their Relationship to War and Peace." *Political Psychology* 30, no. 5 (2009): 721–754. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9221.2009.00723.x

Bertoli, Andrew D. "Nationalism and Conflict: Lessons from International Sports." *International Studies Quarterly* 61, no. 4 (2017): 835–849. https://doi.org/10.1093/isq/sqx029

Session 8, November 25: Public Opinion and Foreign Policy

Draft 3 due Sunday, November 29, 23:59

Most citizens know very little about world politics and hold firm opinions about it anyway. This week asks where those opinions come from. Do leaders pay a real price at home for making a public threat and then backing down? Do elites, who study the public for a living, actually read public opinion correctly, or do they mostly see their own views reflected back at them? Can a foreign government persuade a mass audience abroad through its own state media? And does the public actually behave the way democratic peace theory assumes it does?

*** Tomz, Michael R., and Jessica L. P. Weeks. "Public Opinion and the Democratic Peace." *American Political Science Review* 107, no. 4 (2013): 849–865. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055413000488

– Tomz, Michael. "Domestic Audience Costs in International Relations: An Experimental Approach." *International Organization* 61, no. 4 (2007): 821–840. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0020818307070282

Further readings for this week's presenting team or teams:

Furnas, Alexander C., and Timothy M. LaPira. "The People Think What I Think: False Consensus and Unelected Elite Misperception of Public Opinion." *American Journal of Political Science* 68, no. 3 (2024): 958–971. https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12833

Mattingly, Daniel, et al. "Chinese State Media Persuades a Global Audience That the "China Model" Is Superior: Evidence From a 19-Country Experiment." *American Journal of Political Science* 69, no. 3 (2025): 1029–1046. https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12887

Session 9, December 2: The Psychological Roots of Repression and Political Violence

This closing topic week pulls together threat, identity, and moral judgment to ask a harder question. Why do governments turn to repression, who carries it out, and what does living through it do to the people who survive it.

*** Nugent, Elizabeth R. "The Psychology of Repression and Polarization." *World Politics* 72, no. 2 (2020): 291–334. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0043887120000015

– Gohdes, Anita R., and Sabine C. Carey. "Canaries in a Coal-Mine? What the Killings of Journalists Tell Us About Future Repression." *Journal of Peace Research* 54, no. 2 (2017): 157–174. https://doi.org/10.1177/0022343316680859

Further readings for this week's presenting team or teams:

Carey, Sabine C., and Anita R. Gohdes. "Understanding Journalist Killings." *Journal of Politics* 83, no. 4 (2021): 1216–1228. https://doi.org/10.1086/715172

Young, Lauren E. "The Psychology of State Repression: Fear and Dissent Decisions in Zimbabwe." *American Political Science Review* 113, no. 1 (2019): 140–155. https://doi.org/https://doi.org/10.1017/S000305541800076X

Sessions 10 and 11, Saturday, December 5: Design Presentations

Our usual seminar rooms, A 5, 6, Room B 143, will hold the two sessions (10:00am - 11:30am and 12:30pm - 2:00pm) on December 5 (Saturday) for the design presentations. Each session is a normal 90-minute presentation panel, expecting a 60-minute break. 25 presenters at 7 minutes each (5-minute presentation, 2-minute quick feedback) fill 175-minute, leaving a 5-minute to spare in total.

No new reading. See the design presentation guideline for the expectations.

Sessions 12-14, December 9: Wrap-up, General Feedback on Presentations, Future Directions

Wrap-up and general feedback. We return to the rationalist question from session one, now with 8 weeks of evidence and 25 design presentations behind us. No new reading. Come with an answer you are willing to defend, and bring one thing from a classmate's design presentation that changed how you think about your own topic.

Future directions. Below are examples of some recent and established research, letters, and/or reviews that may inspire those interested in pushing the literature's boundaries. We briefly tap into each one. Then we will end this last session (thank you all in advance for being involved in the class).

Computational Approaches:

- Pacheco, Andre G. C., Athus Cavalini, and Giovanni Comarela. "Echoes of power: Investigating geopolitical bias in US and China large language models." *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications* 13, no. 1 (2026): 675. https://doi.org/10.1057/s41599-026-06577-6

Evolutionary Psychology:

- Miller, Ross. "Looks that kill: Facial metrics and international conflict 1947–2010." *Politics and the Life Sciences* (2026): 1–23. https://doi.org/10.1017/pls.2026.10024

Genetics:

- Cranmer, Skyler J., and Christopher T. Dawes. "The heritability of foreign policy preferences." *Twin Research and Human Genetics* (2012): 52–59. https://doi.org/10.1375/twin.15.1.52

Hormones:

- De Dreu, Carsten K. W., et al. "Oxytocin promotes human ethnocentrism." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 108, no. 4 (2011): 1262–1266. https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1015316108

Neuroscience:

- Ratia-Avinent, Jorge, and Emilie A. Caspar. "Wired for conflict? Neurocognitive mechanisms linking threat perception and support for war." *Neuroscience & Biobehavioral Reviews* (2026): 106713. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.neubiorev.2026.106713

Personality Traits:

- Chagas-Bastos, Fabricio H. "A comprehensive aspect-level approach to the personality microfoundations of foreign policy attitudes." *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin* 50, no. 10 (2024): 1517–1528. https://doi.org/10.1177/01461672231213899

Sleep:

- Lesku, John A. "Dangers of sleeping, and not sleeping enough, in war." *Sleep* 48 (2025): 1–3. https://doi.org/10.1093/sleep/zsae298

Final draft due: Sunday, December 13, 23:59

Important note: This syllabus gives an overview and may change during the term. Any change will be announced by email and an updated version will be posted on Ilias.